

OnePlus Nord Buds 4

Warm sound, well-rounded experience

Buying truly wireless earbuds under Rs 4000 is both easy and confusing. Easy because there is no shortage of options, and confusing because almost every pair promises the same things: active noise cancellation (ANC), bigger drivers, long battery life and AI-powered features. On paper, they often look nearly identical. The real differences only become apparent after using them for a few days. I have been using the OnePlus Nord Buds 4 as my primary earbuds for work, music, videos and calls for a week to find out whether they justify their Rs 3299 price tag. They promise features such as up to 52dB active noise cancellation, 12mm dynamic drivers, a six-microphone AI Clear Call system, up to 47ms low-latency gaming mode, up to 54 hours of battery life and some AI-powered features. The answer to whether they're worth buying is already in the title, but the real question is how well these features perform in everyday use. Let's find that out.

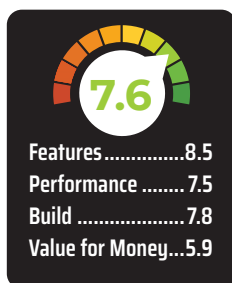
DESIGN

However good-looking or good-performing a TWS earbuds pair is, if the case isn't portable enough, then it fails the point. The good thing is Nord Buds 4's case is compact and chic in looks and profile. Even the firmness with which the hinge snaps adds to the earbuds' appeal. The teal colour is easy on the eyes, but it can get worn out.

Inside, the earbuds have a tried-and-true stem form. The fit and comfort are also superb. The default ear tip worked fine, but you can swap it with the alternative pairs in the box.

Last but not least, the OnePlus Nord Buds 4 carry an IP55 rating, which

₹3,299



means they should easily withstand sweat during workouts or light rain.

SOUND QUALITY

OnePlus Nord Buds 4 share the infatuation that most budget earbuds have for bass. While the bass here isn't too much, it is still more noticeable than on a Realme Buds Air 8. This is true for the sub-bass in Childish Gambino's 'Retro', and the reverb in 'Retrograde' by James Blake, which feel a lot more tighter on the Realme earbuds pair.

In another test track, 'Feel Good Inc' by Gorillaz, the guitar bassline sounded deeper and punchier on the Realme Buds Air 8. Meanwhile, Damon Albarn's vocals also sound clearer, while the rap verses were easier to follow. The OnePlus Nord Buds 4 delivered an enjoyable listening experience, but the Realme earbuds brought forward more detail from the track. Even the signature laughter effects sounded more open and prominent on the Realme, whereas they felt slightly recessed on the OnePlus.

Basically, with OnePlus, you can expect a smoother, more relaxed char-

acter that many listeners may actually prefer during longer listening sessions.

Meanwhile, in the treatment of higher frequencies, the Realme Buds Air 8 does a cleaner job. The OnePlus Nord Buds 4 sounded itsy bitsy shrill in the elevated portions of 'Dawn of the Iconoclast' by Dead Can Dance. The opening drum sequence and percussion in the same track sounded weaker on the OnePlus earbuds, but had some weight in the Realme earbuds' presentation.

That said, all these differences aren't large enough to take away from the overall listening experience, and for casual listeners switching between genres, the Nord Buds 4 deliver a warm and enjoyable sound signature.

By the way, I tried all of these with the Balanced (default) EQ preset with BassWave feature disabled. The latter dynamically boosts bass in tracks. Within the HeyMelody companion app, you can enable Gaming mode for low latency in fast-paced titles. We'll talk more about this app later. So, all in all, you have options to tweak the sound to some extent, which is good.

ANC AND CALL QUALITY

The Nord Buds 4 with its 52dB ANC ceiling, can reduce the background noises, be it office chatter, clacking of keyboard keys, traffic noises, AC, fan and vacuum cleaner noises to a great extent. But the Realme Buds Air 8 offers a marginally better cancellation up to 55dB, which is noticeable if you really pay attention.

So, the noise doesn't vanish completely, but it becomes far less distracting. As for the various ANC modes available, the High mode offers more aggressive noise cancellation, and the Moderate mode was also effective in cancelling most of the noises and was slightly less overpowering.

Transparency mode is suitable for brief conversations or hearing announcements without removing the earbuds. Voices sound normal, but you can feel there is a thin sieve in between.